Stelan Briyan Simonsz

Sri Lanka
+94 77 371 0072
stelan.bz@gmail.com

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I am writing to apply for the Lead Engineer role in Auckland. I am currently based in Sri Lanka, eager to relocate to New Zealand, and able to work from the Auckland office. I will require visa sponsorship for the move.

I bring 10 years of software engineering experience with a strong backend foundation, having spent the last few years operating as a hands-on Tech Lead. To me, technical leadership means staying close to the code - collaborating with product owners from rough requirements to shipped features, driving system design, reviewing code, and staying on top of production issues until they are resolved.

Recent Impact & Experience

- **Backend & AI Engineering at Aventude:** I currently lead backend engineering for Norwegian government and municipal products using Java and Spring Boot. On the Compose platform, I reduced critical API response times from ~10 seconds to under 400ms. I also architected and shipped a legal chatbot in Python and LangGraph, building out hybrid search, reranking, and automated evaluation pipelines to ensure response quality before release.
- **High-Scale Reliability at Circles.Life:** Previously, as a Staff Engineer and Tech Lead, I worked on telecom platforms serving over 150M users. I led zero-downtime launches for ONIC, AT&T, and Telkomsel. By resolving database bottlenecks, optimizing slow APIs, and implementing observability with New Relic and Grafana, my team maintained zero P1 or P2 incidents for six months across the services I owned.

Technical Stack & Approach

My core stack includes Java, Spring Boot, and Python, building REST APIs and microservices backed by PostgreSQL, MySQL, MongoDB, and Redis. I am an AWS Certified Solutions Architect (Associate) with production experience across AWS, Azure, and Kubernetes, and I have also shipped code in Scala, React, C#, and Node.js. I use AI tools daily to accelerate development, and I have delivered production LLM features - including a workflow assistant that eliminated manual configuration - backed by rigorous pre-release evals.

Domain Adaptability & Hardware Context

While my background is outside agriculture, I have a proven track record of quickly mastering complex domains and shipping reliable software within them, spanning core banking, telecom, and government systems. Furthermore, I built Smart Shoes, an AI and IoT product for the visually impaired. Building software that had to function reliably on physical hardware in the real world gave me a deep appreciation for the exact kind of hardware-software intersection Halter operates in.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my background in scaling resilient backend systems and leading engineering teams can contribute to Halter. Thank you for your time and consideration.

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